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Records show out-of-state police departments are searching the college's network of ALPR cameras far more than local law enforcement.

By David Hodges and Gray News staff

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CHARLOTTE, N.C. (WBTV/Gray News) - Records obtained from the University of North Carolina at Charlotte show that out-of-state police departments are searching the college's network of Automatic License ent.

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The agency that se and May 2026 was the Houston P arches that included the UNC C gh May 2026.

Charlotte-Mecklenb e network. UNC Charlotte Police De onth period.

Cameras fee

As cars drive by the capture license plate numbers and ncies across the country can search ited to law enforcement, but th s that are included in the network.

Records from UNC Charlotte show that when Houston officers searched a license plate in the Flock system, they often searched more than 6,000 networks across the country, while many other departments appeared to limit their searches to fewer networks.

Students approached on campus were unable to guess which agencies searched the network most.

"Houston, Texas?!? Wow. OK. Interesting!!" said Verity Morgan, a student who recently hosted a campus debate on Flock cameras.

"Houston??? Why is Houston looking at Charlotte?" said Radhika Chaudha, a student.

"I mean what rights do people have now? You're losing your right to privacy and you don't have a

“In my personal opinion, I don’t see why they’re necessary for our campus,” Morgan said.

“Money could definitely go to different things, I would say. And then it’s kind of creepy that people in Houston are trying to figure out what we got going on over here,” said Peyton Marshall, a student.

In an email stateme use of automated license plate recogn gularly reviewed. The department ha

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Attorney trac

Mark Williams, an a ed to opposing Flock cameras and have helped reveal which police s across the state.

“This is a mass government surveillance system that has been built throughout the state of North Carolina,” Williams said.

Williams warned that while there are rules in North Carolina limiting what law enforcement can use the data for, other agencies in other states lack some of the same guidelines. Meaning UNC Charlotte can’t control how the data their cameras capture is used.

“Under North Carolina law, you can’t sell the data. Texas has no guardrails. Most of those places don’t have rules against selling the data, how it’s used, and who has access to it. That’s a problem,” Williams said.

University responds

UNC Charlotte denied WBTV’s request for an interview with Police Chief Jeffrey Baker.

The university’s Director of Media Relations wrote in an email: “UNC Charlotte participates in a shared law enforcement network that includes approximately 1,600 agencies. When a law

may be included in that query. If the plate has been detected, the system returns the location, date and time of the detection."

The university said the technology has helped University police in a wide variety of cases, including the arrest [illegible] 00,000 in equipment stolen fr [illegible] ovided the arrest record nearly a mo[illegible]

UNC Charlotte said [illegible] entities such as homeowner associa[illegible] ce agencies that searched the netwo[illegible] oledo, Ohio.

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UNC Charlotte is n[illegible] encies. Appalachian State [illegible] UNC Chapel Hill made the same decision last week.

There have been no accusations of misuse of the Flock network at UNC Charlotte. The university says it regularly reviews the system, and officers are required to use specific case numbers any time they search the network.

North Carolina does not require reporting of misuse of the Flock system. Past cases of misuse have come to light when officers were arrested for misusing the system, including at the Charlotte-Mecklenburg Police Department and Mooresville Police Department, or when a department voluntarily reported misuse.

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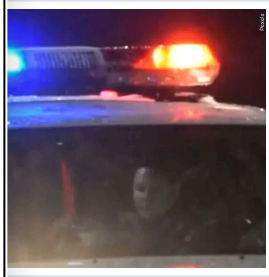
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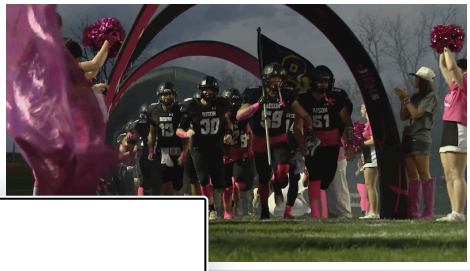


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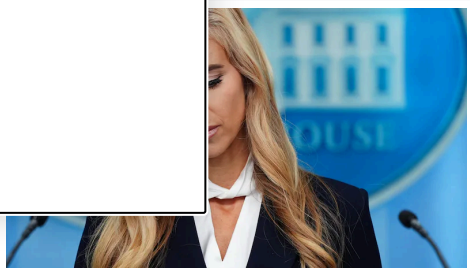


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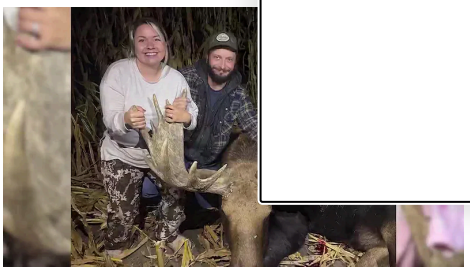
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